How to Write a Research Abstract

A Complete Guide

A Thesis Guide

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Abstract

The abstract is the shortest part of a thesis or research paper, and it is also the most widely read. Long after the full document has been filed in a university library or uploaded to a database, the abstract continues to work on its own: it appears in search results, it is read by examiners deciding whether to accept a thesis for examination, and it is scanned by other researchers deciding whether the full paper is worth their time. A weak abstract can hide good research. A strong abstract makes good research visible.

This guide explains how to write an abstract that does its job in a small number of words. It begins by defining what an abstract is and what it is not, and by distinguishing descriptive abstracts from informative and structured abstracts. It then introduces the four moves every informative abstract must make: stating the problem, describing the method, reporting the results, and drawing a conclusion. Each move is treated in its own chapter, with practical advice on sentence structure, word choice, and the selection of key numbers. Later chapters cover abstracts in different fields, the choice of keywords, word limits and formatting rules, the most common mistakes, and a revision checklist.

The guide is written for undergraduate and postgraduate students who are writing a thesis, a dissertation, a conference paper, or a journal article for the first time. Every principle is illustrated with worked examples. The examples are fictional and are labelled as such; they show the shape of a good abstract rather than reporting real research. By the end of the guide, a student should be able to draft an abstract in a single sitting, revise it against a clear checklist, and submit it with confidence that it represents the research fairly and attracts the readers it deserves.

Keywords: abstract writing; research abstract; structured abstract; academic writing; thesis writing

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How to use this guide: read Chapters 1 to 3 first, to understand what an abstract must do. Then write a rough draft of your own abstract using the four moves. Work through Chapters 4 to 7 to strengthen each move in turn, check Chapters 8 and 9 for the format your field expects, and finish with the revision checklist in Chapter 13 before you submit.

Chapter 1: What an Abstract Is and Why It Matters

An abstract is a short, self-contained summary of a complete piece of research. It states the problem the research addressed, the method used, the main findings, and the conclusion, in a single paragraph or a short set of labelled sections. A reader who reads only the abstract should be able to understand what was done, what was found, and why it matters, without reading the rest of the document. That is a demanding standard for two hundred words, and it is why the abstract is usually the hardest part of a thesis to write well.

The abstract matters because it is often the only part of your work that anyone reads. Search engines and academic databases display the title and the abstract, not the full text. A researcher searching for literature on a topic will read dozens of abstracts in an afternoon and download only a handful of full papers. An examiner may read the abstract before the thesis itself and form a first impression that colours the rest of the examination. A conference committee decides whether to accept a paper largely on the strength of its abstract. In each case, the abstract is the advertisement and

the shop window for months or years of work.

1.1 What an abstract is not

An abstract is not an introduction. An introduction opens a question and leads the reader into the full argument; an abstract closes the question by reporting what the research found. An abstract is not a table of contents, and it is not a promise of what the paper will do. Sentences such as 'This paper will discuss...' belong in an introduction, not in an abstract. An abstract reports what was done and what was found, in the past tense, as completed work.

An abstract is also not a shortened version of the whole paper, produced by cutting out sentences at random. It is a new piece of writing, built from the finished research, in which every sentence earns its place. It contains no new information that does not appear in the main document, no argument that is not supported by the findings, and normally no citations, tables, figures or references. If a reader needs the full paper to understand a sentence in the abstract, that sentence has failed.

1.2 Who reads your abstract, and what do they want?

Three kinds of reader matter most. The first is the searcher: a student or researcher scanning a database for relevant work. They want to know in seconds whether your paper is about their topic, and they decide from your title, your keywords, and the first two sentences of the abstract. The second is the gatekeeper: the examiner, the journal editor, or the conference reviewer who must decide whether the work meets a standard. They want evidence of a clear question, a sound method, and real results. The third is the future citer: a researcher who may build on your findings. They want the key numbers and the precise conclusion, so that they can decide whether your work is relevant to theirs.

All three readers share one trait: they are busy, and they will not work hard to understand you. If the abstract is vague, they will move on to the next one. If it is clear, they will read further. Writing a good abstract is therefore not a matter of style alone; it is a matter of respect for the reader's time, and of giving the research the audience it deserves.

1.3 When to write the abstract

Write the abstract last. This advice surprises students who expect to write a document from the first page to the last, but it follows from what an abstract is: a summary of finished work. You cannot summarise results you have not yet obtained, and you cannot state a conclusion you have not yet reached. Students who write the abstract first usually produce a description of what they hope to do, and then forget to update it when the research changes direction, as research always does.

When the rest of the thesis is complete, set aside an hour, close the full document, and write the abstract from memory and from your notes. Draft it in one sitting, put it aside for a day, and then revise it against the checklist in Chapter 13. Read it aloud: if you stumble over a sentence, the reader will stumble too. Finally, check it against the full document sentence by sentence, to make sure every claim in the abstract is

supported somewhere in the main text.

[ ] I understand that the abstract must stand alone without the full paper.

[ ] I know who will read my abstract and what each reader needs from it.

[ ] I will write the abstract after the rest of the research is finished.

[ ] I will not include citations, tables or figures in the abstract.

Chapter 2: Descriptive, Informative and Structured Abstracts

Not all abstracts do the same job, and the first decision a writer must make is which kind of abstract the situation requires. There are three main kinds: descriptive, informative, and structured. The differences are not matters of taste; they reflect different purposes, different lengths, and different expectations in different fields. Choosing the wrong kind is one of the commonest reasons an abstract is rejected by a journal or a conference.

A descriptive abstract, sometimes called an indicative abstract, describes what the paper is about without reporting its findings. It tells the reader the topic, the scope, and the approach, in about fifty to one hundred words. It is common in the humanities and in some conference programmes, where the purpose is to help readers choose which session to attend. A descriptive abstract answers the question 'What is this paper about?' and leaves the answer to the full paper. It is the easiest kind to write, and the least useful to a reader who wants to know what was found.

2.1 The informative abstract

An informative abstract is the standard form in most of the sciences and social sciences, and it is the main subject of this guide. It reports the purpose, the method, the results, and the conclusions, in about 150 to 300 words. A reader who reads an informative abstract should know what the study found, including the key numbers, and should be able to decide whether the full paper is worth reading. Because it carries real information, it is also the form most examiners and editors expect for a thesis.

The informative abstract is written as a single paragraph in many journals, or as a small number of short paragraphs in a thesis. It uses the past tense for what was done and what was found, and the present tense for conclusions that are presented as general claims. It avoids vague language: 'some improvement' is replaced by the measured improvement, and 'several participants' is replaced by the number of participants. Chapter 3 explains its internal structure in detail.

2.2 The structured abstract

A structured abstract divides the same information under labelled headings, such as Background, Methods, Results, and Conclusions. It is required by many medical, health, and science journals, and it is increasingly used in education and the social sciences. The headings force the writer to include every element, and they help the

reader to find the information they need at a glance. Chapter 8 is devoted to the structured abstract, including the common heading sets and how to use them.

Structured abstracts are usually longer than unstructured ones, because the headings make the structure visible and each section is expected to carry real content. A structured abstract with an empty Results section is worse than no structured abstract at all, because the headings draw attention to what is missing. Do not choose the structured form unless your results are clear enough to fill every heading honestly.

Type	Reports findings?	Typical length	Common in
Descriptive	No - topic and scope only	50-100 words	Humanities, conference programmes
Informative	Yes - purpose, method, results	150-300 words	Sciences, social sciences, theses
Structured	Yes - under labelled headings	200-350 words	Medicine, health, science journals

2.3 Which kind does your situation require?

The answer is always given by the institution, the journal, or the conference, and it is the writer's job to find it and follow it. A thesis handbook will usually state a word limit and sometimes a format. A journal's instructions for authors will state whether the abstract is structured or unstructured, and how many words are allowed. A conference call for papers will state the limit and often gives a sample abstract. Before writing a single word, collect these instructions and keep them beside you while you draft.

When no instruction is given, the informative abstract is the safe default. It serves the most readers, it is accepted almost everywhere, and it demonstrates that the research produced real findings. A descriptive abstract is appropriate only when findings are genuinely not yet available, for example in a conference proposal submitted before the analysis is complete, and even then it should be replaced by an informative abstract as soon as the results are known.

Worked Example: Choosing the right kind

A student submitting a thesis to her university writes an informative abstract of 250 words, reporting her question, her survey of 120 teachers, her main finding, and her conclusion. The same student submitting a proposal to a conference six months earlier, before the survey was complete, writes a descriptive abstract of 80 words describing the topic and the planned method. The two abstracts serve two different purposes, and each

is correct for its situation. The mistake would be to submit the descriptive abstract with the finished thesis, leaving the examiner to guess what was found.

[ ] I have checked whether my university, journal or conference requires a specific abstract type.

[ ] I can explain the difference between a descriptive and an informative abstract.

[ ] If I use a structured abstract, every heading will carry real content.

[ ] I will use an informative abstract when no format is specified.

Chapter 3: The Four Moves: Problem, Method, Results, Conclusion

Every informative abstract, whatever the subject, makes the same four moves. The first move states the problem: what was the question, and why did it matter? The second move describes the method: what was done, with whom or with what, and how? The third move reports the results: what was found, with the key numbers? The fourth move draws the conclusion: what does it mean, and what follows from it? These four moves are the skeleton of the abstract, and they appear in the same order in almost every good abstract ever written.

The order matters. A reader who does not know the problem cannot judge the method. A reader who does not know the method cannot trust the results. A reader who does not know the results cannot assess the conclusion. Writers who begin with results, or who bury the problem in the middle, force the reader to work backwards, and most readers will not bother. Learn the four moves in order, and keep them in order.

3.1 Move one: the problem

The problem move usually takes one or two sentences. It names the topic in general terms, identifies the gap or the difficulty, and states the aim of the study. It should be specific enough that the reader knows what the research is about, but it should not become a mini literature review. One sentence of background is usually enough; two at most. Chapter 4 explains how to write this move well, and how to avoid the common error of spending half the abstract on background.

3.2 Move two: the method

The method move usually takes two or three sentences. It names the design, the participants or the materials, the instruments, and the analysis. It gives numbers: how many people took part, how long the study ran, what was measured. It does not give a full description of the procedure; that belongs in the methodology chapter. It gives just enough detail for the reader to judge whether the results are believable. Chapter 5 explains how to choose which details to include.

3.3 Move three: the results

The results move is the heart of the abstract, and it usually takes two or three

sentences. It reports the main findings, in the order of the research questions, with the key numbers attached. It reports the most important findings, not every finding. A study with five findings should report two or three in the abstract; the rest belong in the results chapter. Chapter 6 explains how to select findings and how to present numbers clearly in very little space.

3.4 Move four: the conclusion

The conclusion move usually takes one or two sentences. It states what the findings mean, what the contribution is, and sometimes what should happen next. It must follow from the results actually reported, and it must not claim more than the evidence supports. A conclusion that goes beyond the results is the single most damaging fault in an abstract, because it tells the reader that the writer cannot be trusted with evidence. Chapter 7 explains how to pitch the conclusion at the right level.

Worked Example: The four moves in one abstract (fictional study)

Problem: 'Many secondary school students in public schools struggle with basic algebra, and teachers report that homework completion is low.' Method: 'This study surveyed 150 Grade 9 students and interviewed 12 mathematics teachers in four schools over one term, and compared homework completion with test scores.' Results: 'Students who completed at least four homework tasks a week scored on average 18 marks higher than those who completed one or fewer, and interviews showed that short daily tasks were completed far more often than long weekly ones.' Conclusion: 'The findings suggest that short, frequent homework tasks may improve both completion and achievement in Grade 9 algebra, and schools should consider redesigning homework in this form.' Each sentence does one job, and the four moves appear in order.

Move	Usual length	Question it answers	Common tense
1. Problem	1-2 sentences	What was the question?	Present
2. Method	2-3 sentences	What was done?	Past
3. Results	2-3 sentences	What was found?	Past
4. Conclusion	1-2 sentences	What does it mean?	Present

Notice how short the whole structure is: seven to ten sentences in total. That is all an abstract needs. Students who try to write fifteen or twenty sentences are not writing an abstract; they are writing a summary of the whole thesis, and they will run out of words before they reach the results. The discipline of the four moves is also a

discipline of selection: only the most important sentence about each move survives.

[ ] My draft makes all four moves: problem, method, results, conclusion.

[ ] The moves appear in that order.

[ ] No move is missing, and no move takes more than three sentences.

[ ] The conclusion follows from the results I actually reported.

Chapter 4: Writing the Problem and Background

The opening sentences of an abstract carry a heavy load. They must tell a stranger what the research is about, why it matters, and what question it asked, in about forty words. Writers often fail here in one of two opposite ways. Some write so generally that the opening could belong to any study in the field: 'Education is important in the modern world.' Others write so specifically that a reader outside their narrow topic cannot follow: a sentence full of unexplained terms and local details. The aim is a middle path: a clear statement of the problem that any educated reader can understand, followed by the precise question the study asked.

Begin with the problem, not with the topic. A topic is a field, such as 'student motivation' or 'water quality'. A problem is a difficulty, a gap, or an unanswered question within that field. 'Students in rural schools score lower in mathematics than students in urban schools, and the reasons are not well understood' is a problem. 'This study is about mathematics in rural schools' is only a topic. The reader needs the problem, because the problem is what makes the research worth doing.

4.1 From the general to the specific in two sentences

A reliable pattern is to open with one sentence of context and follow it with one sentence stating the gap and the aim. The context sentence names the broad situation: a policy, a practice, a known difficulty. The second sentence narrows to the gap: what is not known, what has not been tested, or what works poorly. Then the aim follows, either as part of the second sentence or as a short third sentence: 'This study investigated...' The pattern is simple, but it works in every field, from physics to literature, because it mirrors how readers think: first the situation, then the difficulty, then the response.

Keep the background to a minimum. The abstract is not the place to review the literature or to explain the history of the field. One sentence of context is enough in most cases; two is the maximum. Every sentence spent on background is a sentence that cannot be spent on method or results, and the reader will judge the abstract on its results, not on its background. If you find yourself writing a third background sentence, stop and ask whether the detail belongs in the introduction chapter instead.

4.2 Stating the aim clearly

State the aim with a strong, direct verb. 'This study investigated whether...' or 'This study examined...' are clear and standard. Avoid weak or vague verbs such as 'looked at', 'dealt with', or 'focused on', which tell the reader nothing about what the study

actually did. The aim should name the variables or the phenomenon: not 'student performance' in general, but 'the effect of weekly quizzes on the test scores of Grade 10 science students'. The more precise the aim, the more the reader trusts everything that follows.

The aim and the research question are closely related, and the abstract usually states one of them, not both. If the study has a single clear question, state it as a question or as an aim. If it has several objectives, the abstract should state the main aim only. Do not list three or four objectives in the abstract; there is no room, and the list will crowd out the results.

Worked Example: Weak and strong openings

Weak: 'Education is very important for the development of a country. Many students face problems in their studies. This study looks at the problems of students in schools.' Three sentences, and the reader still does not know what was studied. Strong: 'Grade 9 students in public schools score poorly in algebra, and teachers report that homework is rarely completed. This study investigated whether short daily homework tasks improve completion rates and test scores compared with longer weekly tasks.' Two sentences, and the reader knows the problem, the population, the intervention, and the outcome. The strong version is shorter and says far more.

4.3 Common faults in the opening

- Opening with a dictionary definition or a general statement about the importance of the field.
- Spending three or more sentences on background before the aim appears.
- Using unexplained technical terms in the first sentence, so that only specialists can follow.
- Stating a topic instead of a problem, so the reader cannot tell why the research was needed.
- Promising what the paper will do ('This paper will discuss...') instead of reporting what was done.

[ ] The first sentence names a real problem, not just a topic.

[ ] The aim is stated within the first three sentences.

[ ] The background takes no more than two sentences.

[ ] An educated reader outside my field could understand the opening.

[ ] The aim names the key variables or phenomenon precisely.

Chapter 5: Writing the Method in a Few Sentences

The method section of an abstract is an exercise in selection. The methodology chapter of a thesis may run to twenty pages; the abstract gives it two or three sentences. The writer must therefore choose the details that matter most to a reader who is judging whether the results are believable. Those details are: the design, the participants or materials, the instruments, and the analysis. Everything else can be left to the full paper.

Begin with the design, named in a phrase: 'a quasi-experimental study', 'a survey', 'a case study of two schools', 'a thematic analysis of interview data'. The design tells the reader what kind of evidence to expect, and it sets the standard by which the results will be judged. An experiment that reports a causal claim is judged differently from a survey that reports an association, and the reader needs to know which kind of study they are reading before they reach the results.

5.1 Participants, materials and setting

Give the numbers. How many people took part? How many schools, clinics, or organisations were involved? Over what period did the study run? 'The study surveyed 150 Grade 9 students in four public schools over one term' tells the reader far more than 'The study surveyed students in schools'. Numbers give scale, and scale gives credibility. Where the population matters, name it precisely: the grade, the subject, the type of school, the region. Where the setting matters, name that too.

For studies that do not involve people, the same principle applies to materials: name the data, the sources, and the time period. A study of newspaper coverage should state how many articles were analysed and from which period. A laboratory study should name the materials and the conditions. A study of documents should state how many documents were examined and how they were selected. In every case, the reader should be able to picture the scale of the work.

5.2 Instruments and analysis

Name the main instruments in a phrase: 'a 20-item questionnaire', 'semi-structured interviews', 'a pre-test and a post-test', 'classroom observation over six weeks'. Say briefly how the data were analysed: 'using descriptive statistics and a t-test', 'using thematic analysis', 'using content analysis'. You do not need to justify the choice of analysis in the abstract; the justification belongs in the methodology chapter. You need only to name it, so that the reader knows the findings rest on a recognised procedure.

Do not include procedural detail that only matters to someone repeating the study: the exact wording of every question, the brand of equipment, the step-by-step timetable. Those details belong in the methodology chapter and the appendices. The abstract answers the question 'What was done, broadly, and with whom?' and then moves on to the results.

Worked Example: A method move in three sentences (fictional study)

'A quasi-experimental design was used. A total of 150 Grade 9 students in four public schools were divided into two groups: one group received short daily homework tasks, and the other continued with weekly tasks. Homework completion was recorded for ten weeks, mathematics test scores were measured before and after the intervention, and the results were compared using descriptive statistics and a t-test.' Three sentences carry the design, the sample, the intervention, the measures, the duration, and the analysis. Nothing essential is missing, and nothing unnecessary is included.

5.3 What to leave out

- Step-by-step procedures, which belong in the methodology chapter.
- The full wording of questionnaires or interview schedules, which belong in an appendix.
- Justifications for methodological choices, which belong in the methodology chapter.
- Pilot studies, unless the pilot changed the main study in an important way.
- Ethical approval details, unless the study raises unusual ethical questions.

[ ] The design is named in the first method sentence.

[ ] The number of participants and the setting are stated.

[ ] The main instruments are named.

[ ] The analysis method is named.

[ ] No step-by-step procedure appears in the abstract.

Chapter 6: Reporting Results with Key Numbers

The results section is the reason the abstract exists. A reader who reaches this section wants to know what was found, and the writer's job is to answer that question directly, with numbers, in the order of the research questions. This is not the place for vague language. 'The intervention was effective' says almost nothing. 'The intervention group improved by 12.8 marks, compared with 1.5 marks in the control group' says everything a reader needs to decide whether to read further.

Report the main findings only. A thesis may have ten findings; the abstract should report the two or three that answer the research questions most directly. Choose them by asking: if the reader remembered only one finding from my study, which one would it be? That finding goes first. The next most important finding goes second. The rest belong in the results chapter. An abstract that tries to report everything ends up reporting nothing clearly.

6.1 Numbers that earn their place

Every number in an abstract must earn its place. The numbers that earn it are the ones that answer the research question: the difference between groups, the change from before to after, the proportion of participants who held a view, the strength of a relationship. Give the number and its context together: not '18 marks' alone, but '18 marks higher than the comparison group'. A number without a comparison is difficult

to interpret, and a reader who cannot interpret a number will not trust it.

Round numbers sensibly. Two decimal places are rarely needed in an abstract, and they waste space. Report percentages to the nearest whole number unless the difference between groups is small. Give the sample size alongside a percentage where it matters: '72 per cent of the 150 students' is clearer than '72 per cent' alone. And report negative or unexpected results honestly. A study that found no difference between two groups should say so plainly. Hiding a null result is dishonest, and an examiner who discovers it in the full thesis will distrust the abstract.

6.2 Order and emphasis

Present the findings in the same order as the research questions, so that the reader can follow the argument from the aim to the answer. Begin each finding with the subject of the finding, not with the method: 'Students who completed daily tasks scored higher...' is clearer than 'The t-test showed a significant difference...'. The statistical test is not the finding; the difference between the groups is the finding. The test belongs in the method section or in a short phrase, not at the front of the results sentence.

Use the past tense for results, because the study is complete. 'Students scored higher' is correct; 'Students score higher' suggests a general truth that a single study cannot establish. Keep the present tense for the conclusion, where a general claim is being made, and keep the past tense for the results themselves. Mixing the two tenses in the results section confuses the reader about what was observed and what is being claimed.

6.3 Qualitative results in an abstract

In a qualitative study there may be no numbers to report, and the results section must instead name the main themes. 'Three themes emerged: teachers valued feedback but lacked time to give it; students wanted feedback on content rather than on grammar; and both groups preferred face-to-face discussion to written comments.' Each theme is stated in a phrase, and one short illustration may follow. The reader should finish the section knowing what the study discovered, even though no number was given.

Qualitative abstracts face a special temptation: to report the method in great detail and the findings in vague generalities. Resist it. The themes are the findings, and they deserve the same prominence that numbers receive in a quantitative abstract. Name each theme precisely, in the order of importance, and avoid filler phrases such as 'a number of interesting themes emerged', which tell the reader nothing at all.

Worked Example: A results move with key numbers (fictional study)

'Students in the daily-homework group improved by an average of 12.8 marks, compared with 1.5 marks in the weekly-homework group, and completed 78 per cent of their tasks, compared with 41 per cent. Interviews showed that short tasks were seen as manageable, while long weekly tasks were often left until the night before the deadline.' Two sentences report the main quantitative finding, the completion finding, and the

qualitative explanation. Every number has a comparison, and the reader can judge the size of the effect at a glance.

Weak phrasing	Why it fails	Stronger phrasing
The results were good.	No information at all	Scores rose by 12.8 marks.
Many students improved.	'Many' is not a number	78 per cent of students improved.
The difference was significant.	Significant is not the finding	The group scored 18 marks higher.
Interesting themes emerged.	No themes are named	Three themes emerged: time, clarity, trust.

- [ ] Only the two or three most important findings are reported.
- [ ] Every finding is reported with a number or a named theme.
- [ ] Every number has a comparison or a context.
- [ ] Findings appear in the order of the research questions.
- [ ] Negative or unexpected results are reported honestly.

Chapter 7: Writing Conclusions and Implications

The conclusion of an abstract answers the question 'What does it mean?' It is the shortest move in the abstract, usually one or two sentences, and it is the easiest to get wrong. Writers go wrong in two opposite directions. Some write a conclusion that merely repeats the results: 'Scores improved by 12.8 marks.' That is not a conclusion; it is a repetition. Others write a conclusion that goes far beyond the results: 'This study proves that daily homework will transform education in the whole country.' That is not a conclusion either; it is an overclaim, and it damages the credibility of everything that came before it.

A good conclusion sits between those two faults. It interprets the results: it says what the findings suggest about the original problem, and what follows from them. It uses careful language: 'suggests', 'indicates', 'supports the view that'. These words, sometimes called hedges, are not signs of weakness. They are signs that the writer understands the limits of a single study, and examiners and editors expect to see them.

7.1 From finding to meaning

To write the conclusion, return to the problem stated in the first move and ask: what does this finding change about that problem? If the problem was that homework was rarely completed, and the finding is that short daily tasks were completed far more often, then the conclusion is that the design of homework, not the willingness of students, may be the main obstacle. That is an interpretation, and it goes one step beyond the finding without leaving the evidence behind. The reader can see how the conclusion follows from the results, and can agree or disagree with the reasoning.

The conclusion should also name the contribution: what is now known that was not known before? The contribution may be small, and it should be stated honestly. 'This study provides the first evidence from public schools in this district that short daily tasks improve completion' is a modest contribution, and it is a real one. Claiming a larger contribution than the study supports is the fastest way to lose a reader's trust.

7.2 Implications and recommendations

Some abstracts add an implication or a recommendation: what should teachers, policymakers, or future researchers do as a result? An implication follows from the findings: 'Schools should consider redesigning homework as short daily tasks.' A recommendation for future research points to the next question: 'Future studies should test whether the effect holds in other subjects and over a longer period.' Include an implication only if there is room and only if it follows directly from the results. A recommendation that goes beyond the evidence is worse than no recommendation at all.

Do not introduce new results in the conclusion, and do not introduce a new topic. The conclusion closes the abstract; it does not open a new argument. If a sentence in your conclusion contains a number or a finding that has not appeared in the results section, move that material into the results section or delete it.

Worked Example: A conclusion pitched at the right level (fictional study)

'The findings suggest that the design of homework tasks, rather than student motivation alone, affects completion and achievement in Grade 9 algebra. Schools that wish to improve both may benefit from replacing long weekly tasks with short daily ones, and future research should test whether the effect holds in other subjects.' The first sentence interprets the finding. The second draws a practical implication and points to the next study. Nothing is claimed that the results do not support, and the words 'suggest' and 'may' mark the limits of the claim.

7.3 The language of cautious claims

- 'The findings suggest...' - for a conclusion supported by the evidence but not proven by it.
- 'The results indicate...' - for a conclusion that follows fairly directly from the data.
- 'The study provides evidence that...' - for a conclusion the data support reasonably strongly.
- Avoid 'proves', 'demonstrates conclusively', and 'shows beyond doubt' for a single small study.

• Avoid 'It is hoped that...' and 'It is expected that...', which state wishes rather than conclusions.

[ ] The conclusion interprets the results rather than repeating them.

[ ] The conclusion follows from the results actually reported.

[ ] Cautious language marks the limits of the claim.

[ ] The contribution is stated honestly, without exaggeration.

[ ] No new result or new topic appears in the conclusion.

Chapter 8: Structured (IMRaD) Abstracts

A structured abstract presents the same four moves under labelled headings, so that the reader can find each part at a glance. The most common heading set follows the structure of the research paper itself: Background, Methods, Results, and Conclusions, sometimes with Objective added at the start. Other heading sets add Participants, Setting, or Intervention. The headings are not decoration; they are a promise that each section contains the information its label describes, and a structured abstract with an empty or vague section breaks that promise.

Structured abstracts are required by many journals in medicine, health, psychology, and the natural sciences, and they are increasingly common in education and the social sciences. They are usually longer than unstructured abstracts, because each heading is expected to carry real content. A structured abstract of 250 words that says nothing under Results is more obviously empty than an unstructured abstract of the same length. Writers should therefore choose the structured form only when their results are clear and complete enough to fill every heading.

8.1 Common heading sets

The simplest and most widely used set is four headings: Background, Methods, Results, Conclusions. Background states the problem and the aim. Methods states the design, participants, and analysis. Results states the main findings with key numbers. Conclusions states the meaning and the implication. A common five-heading variant adds Objective as a separate heading before Methods, so that the aim is stated on its own. In health research, the headings may be more detailed: Objective, Design, Setting, Participants, Intervention, Main Outcome Measures, Results, and Conclusions.

Whichever set is required, follow it exactly. Do not invent extra headings, do not merge two headings into one, and do not leave a heading out because you have little to say under it. If a required heading is difficult to fill, that is useful information: it tells you that part of the study needs more thought, or that the abstract is trying to cover a study that is not yet finished.

8.2 Writing under headings

Each section of a structured abstract is short: usually one to three sentences. The Background section is one or two sentences: the problem and the aim. The Methods section is two or three sentences: the design, the participants, the instruments, and

the analysis. The Results section is two or three sentences: the main findings with key numbers. The Conclusions section is one or two sentences: the interpretation and the implication. The total length is typically 200 to 350 words, depending on the journal.

Because the headings do the work of signposting, the sentences under them can be direct and plain. There is no need for linking phrases such as 'In this study...' at the start of every section, because the heading already tells the reader what the section contains. Write each section as a set of clear statements, and check that no sentence belongs under a different heading. A result reported under Methods, or a method detail reported under Results, shows that the writer has not understood the structure.

Worked Example: A structured abstract (fictional study)

Background: Grade 9 students in public schools score poorly in algebra, and teachers report that homework is rarely completed. This study investigated whether short daily homework tasks improve completion and test scores compared with longer weekly tasks. Methods: A quasi-experimental study was conducted with 150 Grade 9 students in four schools over ten weeks. Completion was recorded daily, test scores were measured before and after the intervention, and groups were compared using descriptive statistics and a t-test. Results: The daily-task group improved by 12.8 marks on average, compared with 1.5 marks in the weekly-task group, and completed 78 per cent of tasks, compared with 41 per cent. Interviews showed that short tasks were seen as manageable, while long tasks were left until the night before the deadline. Conclusions: The design of homework tasks affects completion and achievement. Schools may benefit from replacing long weekly tasks with short daily ones, and future research should test the effect in other subjects.

Heading	Contents	Usual length
Background	Problem, gap and aim	1-2 sentences
Objective	Aim, if listed separately	1 sentence
Methods	Design, participants, instruments, analysis	2-3 sentences
Results	Main findings with key numbers	2-3 sentences
Conclusions	Interpretation and implication	1-2 sentences

[ ] I am using the exact heading set required by the journal or institution.

[ ] Every heading carries real content, not a vague sentence.

[ ] No sentence appears under the wrong heading.

[ ] The total length is within the stated word limit.

[ ] The structured abstract can be read as a coherent whole, not just as separate notes.

Chapter 9: Abstracts Across Fields

The four moves are the same in every field, but the way they are expressed changes. A physics abstract, a sociology abstract, and a history abstract all state a problem, a method, results, and a conclusion, but they do so with different kinds of evidence, different conventions, and different expectations about length and style. A writer who copies the abstract style of one field into another will produce an abstract that looks wrong to its readers, even if the four moves are all present.

The differences are not arbitrary. They follow from what counts as evidence in each field. In the experimental sciences, evidence is a measurement, and the abstract reports numbers. In the social sciences, evidence may be a survey result, an interview theme, or an observed pattern, and the abstract reports the pattern and its strength. In the humanities, evidence is an argument built from texts, and the abstract reports the claim and the reading that supports it. Understanding these differences helps a student write an abstract that fits the expectations of their own field.

9.1 Science and health abstracts

Science abstracts are the most standardised. They are usually structured, they report numbers, and they use the past tense for method and results. A typical science abstract states the question, the experimental design or the data collected, the main quantitative result with its size and its uncertainty, and the conclusion. The language is precise and economical: every word carries information, and there is no room for general reflection. Word limits are often strict, and the abstract may be the only part of the paper that a database displays in full.

Health and medical abstracts follow the same pattern, with added attention to participants, setting, and outcomes. The number of participants, the duration of follow-up, and the main outcome measure are essential information, and an abstract that omits them is incomplete. Ethical approval is sometimes mentioned. The conclusion is stated cautiously, because a single study rarely settles a clinical question.

9.2 Social science abstracts

Social science abstracts are more varied. A quantitative study in education or economics looks much like a science abstract: it reports the sample, the method, and the key numbers. A qualitative study reports themes instead of numbers, and the abstract must name those themes clearly. A mixed-methods study must report both kinds of finding, which makes the abstract longer and harder to write; the writer must decide which finding from each strand deserves a place.

Social science abstracts also carry more context than science abstracts, because the setting matters to the meaning of the findings. A study of 150 students in four public

schools in one district is not the same as a study of 150 students in general, and the abstract should say enough about the setting for the reader to judge how far the findings travel. The conclusion often includes a practical implication for teachers, managers, or policymakers.

9.3 Humanities abstracts

Humanities abstracts are often descriptive rather than informative, and they are usually shorter. A history or literature abstract may state the question, the texts or sources examined, and the argument the paper makes, without reporting findings in the scientific sense. The 'results' move becomes a claim: 'This paper argues that...' followed by the central reading or interpretation. The method move becomes a description of the approach: a close reading of three novels, an analysis of archival records, a comparison of two traditions.

Writers in the humanities should beware of two faults. The first is writing an abstract that is so general that it could describe any paper on the topic: 'This paper explores the theme of identity in modern fiction.' The second is writing an abstract that assumes the reader already knows the texts and the debate. A good humanities abstract names the specific texts, the specific question, and the specific claim, so that a reader outside the specialism can understand what the paper contributes.

Field	Usual form	Results look like	Key demand
Science / health	Structured, 200-350 words	Numbers with comparisons	Precision and completeness
Social science	Informative, 150-300 words	Numbers or named themes	Context and setting stated
Humanities	Descriptive or informative	A central claim or reading	Specific texts and claim named

Whatever the field, the test is the same: can a reader who knows nothing about the study understand what was asked, what was done, what was found, and what it means? If the answer is yes, the abstract works, even if its style differs from the examples in this guide. Read three published abstracts in your own field before you write yours, and notice how they handle the four moves. Imitate their structure, not their sentences.

[ ] I have read three published abstracts in my own field.

[ ] My abstract follows the conventions of my field, not another field.

[ ] The setting and population are stated clearly enough for a reader to judge the scope.

[ ] Qualitative findings are reported as named themes, not vague generalities.

[ ] Humanities claims are specific: texts, question and argument are all named.

Chapter 10: Keywords: Choosing Words That Get Your Work Found

Keywords are the handful of words or short phrases listed after the abstract that tell databases and search engines what the paper is about. They matter more than most students realise. A researcher looking for literature does not read every abstract in a database; they search for keywords, and a paper whose keywords do not match the search terms will never appear in the results. Good keywords are therefore a matter of visibility, not of decoration.

Most universities and journals ask for three to six keywords, listed in alphabetical order or in order of importance. They should be chosen after the abstract is written, not before, because they must reflect what the study actually did, not what it was planned to do. A keyword that appears nowhere in the abstract or the title is a warning sign: either the keyword is wrong, or the abstract has failed to mention an important part of the study.

10.1 What makes a good keyword

A good keyword is specific, standard, and searchable. Specific means that it names the topic precisely: 'peer feedback' is better than 'feedback', and 'Grade 9 algebra' is better than 'mathematics'. Standard means that it uses the terms other researchers in the field use, not a phrase invented for this paper. Searchable means that a researcher looking for work on this topic would plausibly type that word into a search box. The best test is simple: imagine a researcher searching for your paper. What words would they type? Those are your keywords.

Keywords should normally be nouns or noun phrases, not whole sentences and not verbs. They should include the main topic, the population or setting, the method, and the key concept. For a study of peer feedback in Grade 9 algebra, good keywords might be: algebra, homework, mathematics education, peer feedback, secondary school. Each one captures a different aspect of the study, and together they cover the ways a searcher might look for it.

10.2 Common keyword mistakes

- Choosing keywords that are too general: 'education', 'research', 'students'. These match thousands of papers and help nobody find yours.
- Choosing keywords that are too specific or invented, so that nobody would ever search for them.
- Repeating the title word for word, which wastes the chance to add new search terms.
- Using abbreviations that a searcher would not type, or that have more than one meaning.
- Listing more keywords than allowed, which may lead to the extra ones being ignored.

Do not use a keyword for a topic the paper only mentions in passing. If the abstract mentions motivation in one sentence but the study is about homework design, 'motivation' should not be a keyword, because a searcher who finds the paper through that keyword will be disappointed. Keywords are a promise about the content of the paper, and like every promise in academic writing, they should be kept.

Worked Example: Choosing keywords (fictional study)

Title: 'Short Daily Homework Tasks and Achievement in Grade 9 Algebra'. Weak keywords: education, students, learning, homework, school. These are so general that they match almost every paper in the database. Strong keywords: algebra, homework design, mathematics education, peer feedback, secondary school. Each term is specific, each is a term researchers actually use, and together they describe the topic, the intervention, the subject, and the population. A researcher searching for any one of these terms has a good chance of finding the paper.

[ ] I have three to six keywords, as required.

[ ] Each keyword is a term a researcher would plausibly search for.

[ ] The keywords cover the topic, the population, the method and the key concept.

[ ] No keyword is so general that it matches thousands of papers.

[ ] Every keyword reflects content that is actually in the paper.

Chapter 11: Length, Word Limits and Formatting

Every abstract has a word limit, and the limit is not a suggestion. A thesis handbook may allow 300 words; a journal may allow 200; a conference may allow 150. Submitting an abstract that is longer than the limit is one of the easiest ways to have a paper returned without review. Editors and examiners treat the limit as a test of the writer's discipline: if a writer cannot keep an abstract within its limit, they may not be able to keep a paper within its limit either.

The most common limits are 150, 200, 250, and 300 words. A thesis abstract is usually at the upper end of this range, because it must summarise a long document. A journal article abstract is usually between 150 and 250 words. A conference abstract is often the shortest, because it must fit in a printed programme. Before writing, find the limit that applies to your situation and write it at the top of your draft. Then count the words as you revise, and cut until the draft fits.

11.1 Fitting the limit without losing content

Cutting an abstract to fit a limit is a matter of removing words, not removing content. The first words to go are adjectives and adverbs that add emphasis but no information: 'very', 'really', 'important', 'significant' used as praise rather than as a statistical term. The next to go are phrases that can be replaced by a single word: 'due to the fact that' becomes 'because', 'in order to' becomes 'to', 'a large number of' becomes 'many'. Then look for repeated ideas: a sentence that restates the aim in different words can be deleted.

If the abstract is still too long, look at the background. A background of three sentences can usually be cut to one without losing anything the reader needs. If it is still too long, look at the method: procedural details that belong in the methodology chapter can be removed. The results and the conclusion should be the last things to cut, because they are the reason the abstract exists. An abstract that fits the limit by deleting its results has failed.

11.2 Formatting rules

Formatting rules for abstracts are simple, but they must be followed exactly. The abstract is usually a single paragraph, or a set of short paragraphs in a thesis, with no indentation at the start of the first line. It uses the same font and font size as the rest of the document. It contains no headings unless it is a structured abstract, no bullet points, no tables, and no figures. It does not contain citations, and it does not use footnotes.

Check whether the abstract page needs a title, the author's name, or the word 'Abstract' as a heading. In a thesis, the abstract usually appears on its own page, after the title page and before the table of contents. In a journal article, it appears at the top of the first page, under the title and the authors' names. Follow the format of your institution or journal, and do not invent a format of your own.

11.3 One paragraph or several?

Journal abstracts are usually a single paragraph, because they must be short and because databases display them as one block of text. Thesis abstracts are often two or three short paragraphs: one for the problem and method, one for the results, and one for the conclusion. Either form is acceptable where it is the expected form. What matters is that the reader can follow the four moves without effort. If a single paragraph becomes so long that the reader loses track of the moves, split it. If short paragraphs break the flow, join them.

Setting	Usual limit	Usual form
Thesis / dissertation	250-350 words	One page, 2-3 paragraphs
Journal article	150-250 words	Single paragraph
Conference paper	100-200 words	Single paragraph
Structured journal abstract	200-350 words	Labelled sections

These figures are typical, not universal. Always check the specific limit for your situation. A limit of 150 words and a limit of 300 words demand very different abstracts, and a writer who confuses them will either waste space or run out of it.

[ ] I know the exact word limit for my abstract and have written it on my draft.

[ ] My draft is within the limit, counted by a word counter, not by eye.

[ ] No citations, tables, figures or footnotes appear in the abstract.

[ ] The formatting follows the rules of my institution or journal.

[ ] I have not cut results or conclusions to fit the limit.

Chapter 12: Common Mistakes

Most weak abstracts fail in the same small number of ways, and each of those ways is easy to recognise once it has been named. This chapter collects the twelve most common mistakes, explains why each one damages the abstract, and gives the correction. Read it with your own draft in front of you, and check each mistake against your own text. It is far cheaper to fix these faults in the abstract than to have an examiner or an editor point them out.

12.1 The twelve most common mistakes

• No results. The abstract describes the topic and the method but never says what was found. This is the single most common fault, and the most damaging, because the results are the reason the abstract exists.

• Too much background. Half the abstract is spent on the history of the field, leaving no room for the method or the results.

• Vague language. Words such as 'some', 'many', 'improved', and 'effective' appear without numbers, so the reader learns nothing concrete.

• Overclaiming. The conclusion claims more than the results support, using words such as 'proves' or 'transforms'.

• Promising instead of reporting. 'This paper will discuss...' instead of 'This study found...'.

• Missing method. The reader is told the results but not how they were obtained, so the results cannot be trusted.

• Missing problem. The abstract reports findings without ever stating the question they answer.

• Citations in the abstract. References belong in the main text; an abstract should stand alone.

• New information. The abstract contains a claim or a number that does not appear in the main document.

• Abbreviations without explanation. An unexplained abbreviation in the first sentence stops the reader immediately.

• Too long. The abstract exceeds the word limit, or it tries to summarise the whole thesis instead of reporting its essence.

• Copying sentences from the thesis. Sentences lifted from the introduction or the conclusion rarely work as an abstract, because they were written for a different purpose.

12.2 Why these mistakes happen

These mistakes share a common cause: the writer is thinking about the thesis, not about the reader of the abstract. The writer knows the background, so they write too much of it. The writer knows the results, so they assume the reader will find them in the full paper. The writer is proud of the work, so they claim more for it than the evidence supports. The cure is the same in every case: read the abstract as a stranger would read it, with no knowledge of the thesis, and ask whether each sentence earns its place.

A practical way to do this is to give the abstract to a friend in a different subject and ask them three questions: What was the research question? What was found? What does it mean? If they cannot answer all three from the abstract alone, the abstract needs revision. Their confusion is information, not criticism, and it is far better to receive it from a friend than from an examiner.

Worked Example: Spotting the faults

Draft: 'Education is the key to national development. This paper will discuss the problems faced by students in mathematics. A survey was conducted in some schools. The results were very encouraging, and the study proves that homework is the solution to all learning problems.' Faults: vague background, a promise instead of a report, no numbers for the sample, no actual results, and an overclaim in the final sentence. Almost every sentence needs rewriting. Compare with the strong examples in Chapters 4 to 7, where each sentence does one clear job.

[ ] My abstract reports results, with numbers or named themes.

[ ] Background takes no more than two sentences.

[ ] No vague words stand where a number should be.

[ ] The conclusion claims no more than the results support.

[ ] No citations, unexplained abbreviations or new information appear.

Chapter 13: Revision Checklist and Worked Examples

An abstract is never finished in a single draft. The first draft captures the content; the revision makes it clear, accurate, and within the limit. This chapter gives a step-by-step revision process and then presents two worked examples: a weak abstract and a strong abstract on the same fictional study, so that the difference between them can be seen clearly. Work through the revision steps with your own draft, and use the examples as a standard to judge it against.

13.1 A five-step revision process

Step one: put the draft aside for a day. Fresh eyes catch faults that tired eyes miss, and a day is enough for the writer to forget the sentences they meant to write and see the sentences they actually wrote. Step two: read the draft aloud. Sentences that are hard to say aloud are hard to read, and the ear catches repetition and awkward phrasing that the eye passes over.

Step three: check the structure. Underline the sentence that states the problem, the

sentences that describe the method, the sentences that report the results, and the sentence that states the conclusion. If any move is missing, or if a sentence belongs under a different move, rearrange the abstract. Step four: check the facts. Compare every number and every claim in the abstract with the full thesis, and correct any difference, however small. Step five: count the words, cut to the limit, and check the formatting against the rules of your institution or journal.

13.2 Worked example: a weak abstract

The weak abstract below is based on a fictional study. It is typical of first drafts, and it contains most of the mistakes listed in Chapter 12. Read it critically before reading the commentary that follows.

Worked Example: Weak abstract (fictional study)

'Education is very important for every country in the world today. Mathematics is a difficult subject and many students have problems with it. This paper will discuss the problems of students and will look at homework in schools. A survey was conducted and interviews were done with some teachers. The results were good and show that homework is useful. This study proves that homework can solve the problems of education and will change the whole system.' Commentary: the first two sentences are general background that say nothing about the study. The third sentence promises rather than reports. The method gives no numbers: how many students, how many teachers, how many schools? The results give no numbers either: what improved, and by how much? The final sentence overclaims wildly. A reader learns nothing concrete from this abstract, and would not read the full paper.

13.3 Worked example: a strong abstract

The strong abstract below reports the same fictional study. Notice how each sentence does one job, how the four moves appear in order, and how every claim is supported by a number or a specific finding.

Worked Example: Strong abstract (fictional study)

'Grade 9 students in public schools score poorly in algebra, and teachers report that homework is rarely completed. This study investigated whether short daily homework tasks improve completion rates and test scores compared with longer weekly tasks. A quasi-experimental study was conducted with 150 Grade 9 students in four schools over ten weeks. Completion was recorded daily, test scores were measured before and after the intervention, and the groups were compared using descriptive statistics and a t-test. Students in the daily-task group improved by 12.8 marks on average, compared with 1.5 marks in the weekly-task group, and completed 78 per cent of their tasks, compared with 41 per cent. Interviews with 12 teachers showed that short tasks were seen as manageable, while long weekly tasks were often left until the night before the deadline. The findings suggest that the design of homework tasks affects completion and achievement in Grade 9 algebra, and schools may benefit from replacing long weekly tasks with short daily ones.' Commentary: the problem and the aim appear in the first two

sentences. The method gives the design, the sample, the duration, the measures, and the analysis. The results give the key numbers with comparisons, and the qualitative finding that explains them. The conclusion interprets the findings with cautious language and draws a practical implication. The abstract is about 200 words long, and a reader who reads only this abstract knows what was asked, what was done, what was found, and what it means.

13.4 The final revision checklist

[ ] All four moves are present, in order: problem, method, results, conclusion.

[ ] The problem and aim appear within the first three sentences.

[ ] The method names the design, the sample, the instruments and the analysis.

[ ] The results report the main findings with key numbers or named themes.

[ ] The conclusion follows from the results and claims no more than they support.

[ ] The abstract is within the word limit.

[ ] Every number in the abstract matches the full thesis.

[ ] No citations, tables, figures, abbreviations or new information appear.

[ ] Keywords are specific, standard and searchable.

[ ] The abstract has been read aloud and checked by a reader outside my field.

Chapter 14: Conclusion

The abstract is a small piece of writing with a large responsibility. In two hundred words it must tell a stranger what you asked, what you did, what you found, and what it means. That is a demanding task, and it is why the abstract is written last, revised carefully, and checked against the full thesis before it is submitted. But it is also a learnable skill. The four moves in this guide appear in every good abstract, in every field, and a writer who masters them can write an abstract for any study.

Remember the principles that matter most. Write the abstract after the research is finished. Make all four moves, in order, and give each move the space it deserves. Report results with numbers, not with vague praise. Claim no more than the evidence supports. Choose keywords that a searcher would actually type. And keep the abstract within its word limit, because the limit is part of the task, not an obstacle to it.

Above all, remember who the abstract is for. It is not for you, and it is not for your supervisor. It is for the stranger in a database, the examiner with a pile of theses, and the researcher deciding whether your work is worth an afternoon of their time. Write for that reader, clearly and honestly, and the research will find the audience it deserves. Good luck with your abstract, and with the research behind it.

Suggested Reading

The following are general, well-known types of works that students commonly consult when learning to write abstracts and academic papers. Check your university library

for the latest editions, and follow your department's guidance on referencing style.

- General research methods textbooks: standard methodology texts used in most universities explain research design, sampling, data collection and analysis, and usually include a chapter on writing up research.
- Academic writing guides: widely used guides to writing theses, dissertations and journal articles explain structure, argument and style, with examples of abstracts and introductions.
- Style manuals: the official manuals of the major referencing styles are the authoritative source for citation, formatting and abstract requirements; consult the edition your department requires.
- Journal instructions for authors: the author guidelines of journals in your own field state the required abstract type, word limit and heading set, and often give a sample abstract.
- Your university's thesis regulations and template: always the first and final authority on the abstract's length, format and position in the thesis.
- Your supervisor's recommended reading list for your subject: the most relevant source of all, because it is chosen for your specific topic and method.